

Safe from space: On the return of the NASA mission space crew

NASA did well to follow **established protocol** in bringing astronauts back

In the early hours (IST) of March 19, 2025, a SpaceX crew capsule bearing NASA astronauts Sunita Williams, Barry Wilmore, Nick Hague, and Roscosmos **cosmonaut** Aleksandr Gorbunov **splashed down off** Florida. Ms. Williams and Mr. Wilmore had returned to the earth after nine months in the International Space Station (ISS), whereas they had originally been expected to spend eight days **in the course of** testing Boeing's Starliner **crew** capsule. The Starliner **saga** has now **concluded**, but not before it **twisted** the reality of human spaceflight out of context, making it sound like a **caper** rather than a **testament** to the **virtues** of protocol. **Following** Starliner's launch in June 2024, a **series of malfunctions left** Ms. Williams and Mr. Wilmore **onboard** the ISS before the capsule returned empty to the ground in September. The **events spurred** concerns and **indignation** in the popular imagination, **swirling** around a **dearth** of information both NASA and Boeing **were reluctant** to fill. As their stay was expanded to nine months, curiosity **swelled** over their **well-being**. While this response was natural, **speculation fuelled** by insufficient updates and political propaganda in the U.S. also **fanned** misinformation that cast Ms. Williams and Mr. Wilmore as having been "**stranded**" in space.

If the "stranded" **narrative** captures the **gist** of Starliner's failure, it misses the **inalienable contingencies** at the heart of human spaceflight. Ms. Williams herself has **sought to downplay** the use of such terms. Over the years, but especially **in the wake of** the Challenger and Columbia **shuttle** disasters in 1986 and 2003, NASA has **instituted** procedures its personnel are required to follow in a variety of situations where events **buck** a pre-planned sequence. One is that astronauts onboard malfunctioning spacecraft can move to the ISS, which is always prepared to **host** such visitors. But many actors framed NASA as **weak-willed** for **sticking** to its protocols. When it **scrubbed** a prior launch attempt of the capsule that returned the astronauts for technical reasons, **supporters** of U.S. President Donald Trump **accused** the agency **of infirmity** rather than **acknowledging** it as a well-known safety measure. **Narratives** that **overlook** the simple fact that two **veterans** were picked to pilot Starliner's first crewed flight **belie** the existence of multiple safety checkpoints and the great lengths to which space agencies go to ensure one unexpected **outcome** does not **spell catastrophe**. **People**, including in India — where concern for Ms. Williams **parallels** a growing pride in the country's **budding** human spaceflight programme **owing to** her Indian **ancestry** — **would** do well to replace **notions of triumphalism** in space with good old "safety first". Also, space agencies should realise the importance of clear, timely communication as an **integral** part of safety protocol. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Cosmonaut** (noun) – a Russian astronaut.
- Weak-willed (adjective) – lacking the ability to resist the influence of other people or to control one's own impulses. कमजोर इरादों वाली

Vocabulary

1. **Established** (adjective) – Recognized, Accepted, Proven, Traditional, Settled
स्थापित
2. **Protocol** (noun) – Procedure, Guideline, Rule, Standard, Framework प्रोटोकॉल
3. **Splash down** (phrasal verb) – (of a spacecraft) land on water. पानी में उतरना
4. **Off** (preposition) – Near, Close to, Beside, Alongside, Adjacent to के पास
5. **In the course of** (phrase) – During, Throughout, Over, While, Amidst के दौरान
6. **Crew** (noun) – Team, Staff, Personnel, Squad, Unit दल
7. **Saga** (noun) – Story, Tale, Narrative, Chronicle, Episode गाथा
8. **Conclude** (verb) – End, Finish, Complete, Terminate, Wrap up समाप्त करना
9. **Twist** (verb) – Distort, Misrepresent, Alter, Misinterpret, Manipulate मोड़ना
10. **Caper** (noun) – an illicit or ridiculous activity or escapade. बेहूदा मजाक
11. **Testament** (noun) – Proof, Evidence, Testament, Confirmation, Demonstration साक्ष्य
12. **Virtue** (noun) – Quality, Merit, Advantage, Strength, Excellence गुण
13. **Following** (preposition) – After, Subsequent to, In the wake of, Post, Behind के बाद
14. **Malfunction** (noun) – Failure, Breakdown, Glitch, Defect, Fault खराबी
15. **Onboard** (verb) – Embark, Load, Enlist, Join, Enter सवार होना
16. **Spur** (verb) – Encourage, Stimulate, Prompt, Provoke, Motivate प्रेरित करना
17. **Indignation** (noun) – Anger, Outrage, Resentment, Fury, Wrath आक्रोश
18. **Swirl** (verb) – Spin, Whirl, Twirl, Circulate, Churn घूमना
19. **Dearth** (noun) – Lack, Shortage, Scarcity, Deficiency, Absence कमी
20. **Reluctant** (adjective) – Hesitant, Unwilling, Resistant, Disinclined, Averse अनिच्छुक
21. **Swell** (verb) – Increase, Grow, Expand, Rise, Surge बढ़ना
22. **Well-being** (noun) – Health, Welfare, Happiness, Comfort, Prosperity कल्याण
23. **Speculation** (noun) – Guess, Conjecture, Hypothesis, Assumption, Theory अटकल
24. **Fuel** (verb) – Stimulate, Encourage, Provoke, Ignite, Inflammation भड़काना

25. **Fan** (verb) – Stir, Whip up, Inflammate, Aggravate, Intensify भड़काना
26. **Stranded** (adjective) – Marooned, Abandoned, Isolated, Trapped, Deserted फंसा हुआ
27. **Narrative** (noun) – Story, Account, Tale, Chronicle, Report कथा
28. **Gist** (noun) – Essence, Core, Main point, Summary, Substance मुख्य बिंदु
29. **Inalienable** (adjective) – Unassailable, Absolute, Inviolable, Sacrosanct, Untouchable अविच्छेद्य
30. **Contingency** (noun) – Possibility, Eventuality, Emergency, Uncertainty, Risk आकस्मिकता
31. **Seek** (verb) – Pursue, Search, Aim, Strive, Request तलाश करना
32. **Downplay** (verb) – Understate, Minimize, Underplay, Diminish, Belittle कम करके बताना
33. **In the wake of** (phrase) – After, Following, Subsequent to, As a result of, Post के बाद
34. **Shuttle** (noun) – It is short for space shuttle. शटल
35. **Institute** (verb) – Establish, Create, Found, Launch, Initiate स्थापित करना
36. **Buck** (verb) – Resist, Oppose, Defy, Challenge, Withstand विरोध करना
37. **Host** (verb) – Accommodate, Welcome, Entertain, Lodge, Receive मेजबानी करना
38. **Stick** (to) (verb) – Adhere, Follow, Abide by, Comply, Persist पालन करना
39. **Scrub** (verb) – Cancel, Abandon, Halt, Stop, Call off रद्द करना
40. **Accuse** (of) (verb) – Blame, Charge, Indict, Implicate, Allege आरोप लगाना
41. **Infirmity** (noun) – Weakness, Frailty, Disability, Ailment, Debility कमजोरी
42. **Acknowledge** (verb) – Admit, Recognize, Accept, Concede, Confirm स्वीकार करना
43. **Overlook** (verb) – Ignore, Neglect, Miss, Disregard, Skip नज़रअंदाज़ करना
44. **Veteran** (noun) – Expert, Professional, Seasoned, Experienced, Master दिग्गज
45. **Belie** (verb) – Contradict, Misrepresent, Disguise, Conceal, Mask झुठलाना
46. **Outcome** (noun) – Result, Consequence, Effect, Conclusion, End परिणाम
47. **Spell** (verb) – Mean, Signify, Indicate, Imply, Herald मतलब होना
48. **Catastrophe** (noun) – Disaster, Calamity, Tragedy, Mishap, Crisis तबाही

49. **Parallel** (verb) – Match, Correspond, Resemble, Echo, Mirror समानांतर होना

50. **Budding** (adjective) – Growing, Developing, Emerging, Flourishing बढ़ता हुआ,

51. **Owing to** (phrase) – Due to, Because of, Thanks to, As a result of, On account of के कारण

52. **Ancestry** (noun) – Heritage, Lineage, Descent, Origin, Pedigree वंश

53. **Notion** (noun) – Idea, Concept, Belief, Thought, Perception धारणा

54. **Triumphalism** (noun) – Boastfulness, Arrogance, Overconfidence, Pride, Exultation विजयोत्सास

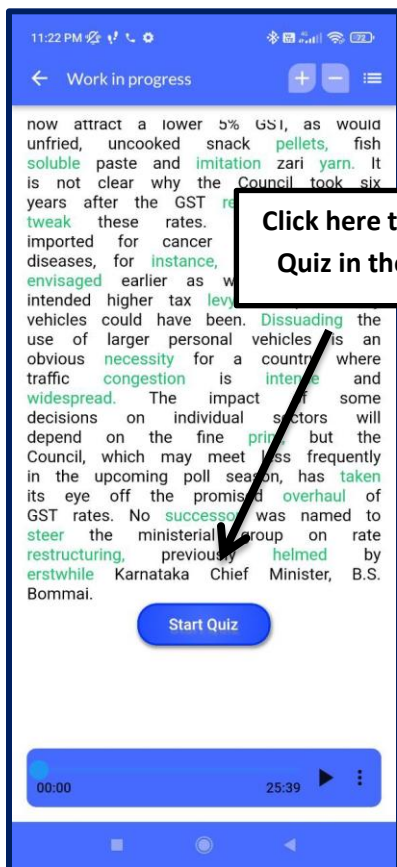
55. **Integral** (adjective) – Essential, Fundamental, Crucial, Vital, Necessary अभिन्न

@mocks_wallah

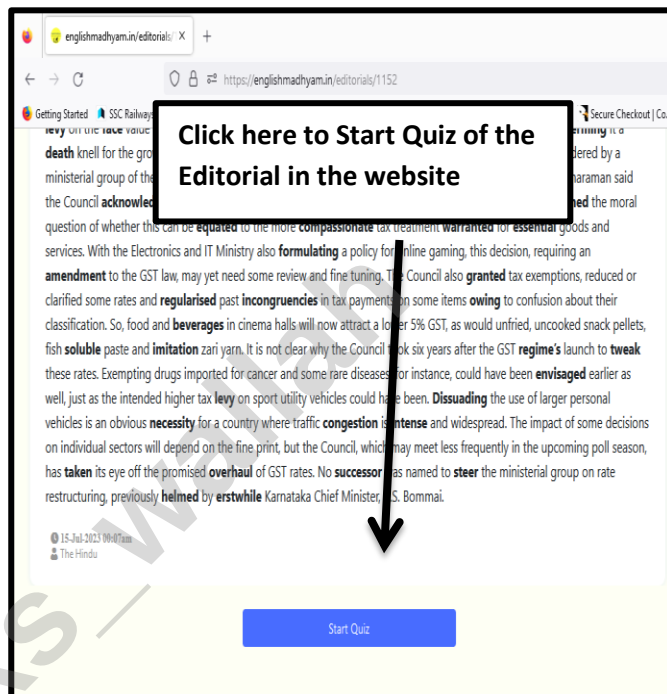
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Successful Return:** On March 19, 2025, a SpaceX crew capsule safely returned NASA astronauts Sunita Williams, Barry Wilmore, Nick Hague, and Roscosmos cosmonaut Aleksandr Gorbunov to Earth, splashing down off Florida.
2. **Extended Stay:** Williams and Wilmore spent nine months on the ISS, far longer than the originally planned eight days, due to malfunctions with Boeing's Starliner crew capsule.
3. **Starliner Saga:** The Starliner mission, intended to test Boeing's capsule, faced multiple malfunctions after its June 2024 launch, leading to the astronauts' prolonged stay on the ISS.
4. **Public Concerns:** The extended mission sparked public concern and misinformation, with some portraying Williams and Wilmore as "stranded" in space.
5. **NASA's Protocol:** NASA adhered to established safety protocols, including the option for astronauts to stay on the ISS if their spacecraft malfunctioned.
6. **Misinformation:** Insufficient updates from NASA and Boeing, combined with political propaganda, fueled speculation and misinformation about the astronauts' situation.
7. **Downplaying "Stranded" Narrative:** Williams herself rejected the "stranded" narrative, emphasizing the importance of safety protocols in spaceflight.
8. **Historical Context:** NASA's protocols were strengthened after the Challenger (1986) and Columbia (2003) shuttle disasters to handle unexpected situations.
9. **Criticism of NASA:** Some critics, including supporters of former U.S. President Donald Trump, accused NASA of being weak-willed for adhering to safety measures, such as scrubbing a prior launch attempt.
10. **Veteran Astronauts:** Williams and Wilmore, both experienced astronauts, were chosen for Starliner's first crewed flight, highlighting NASA's emphasis on safety and preparedness.
11. **Safety Checkpoints:** The mission underscored the multiple safety checkpoints and rigorous measures space agencies implement to prevent catastrophic outcomes.
12. **Global Attention:** Williams' Indian ancestry drew significant attention in India, where pride in the country's growing human spaceflight program is rising.
13. **Triumphalism vs. Safety:** The episode serves as a reminder to prioritize safety over triumphalism in space exploration.
14. **Importance of Communication:** Clear and timely communication from space agencies is crucial to prevent misinformation and maintain public trust.
15. **Lessons Learned:** The Starliner mission highlights the need for robust safety protocols, transparent communication, and public understanding of the inherent risks in human spaceflight.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



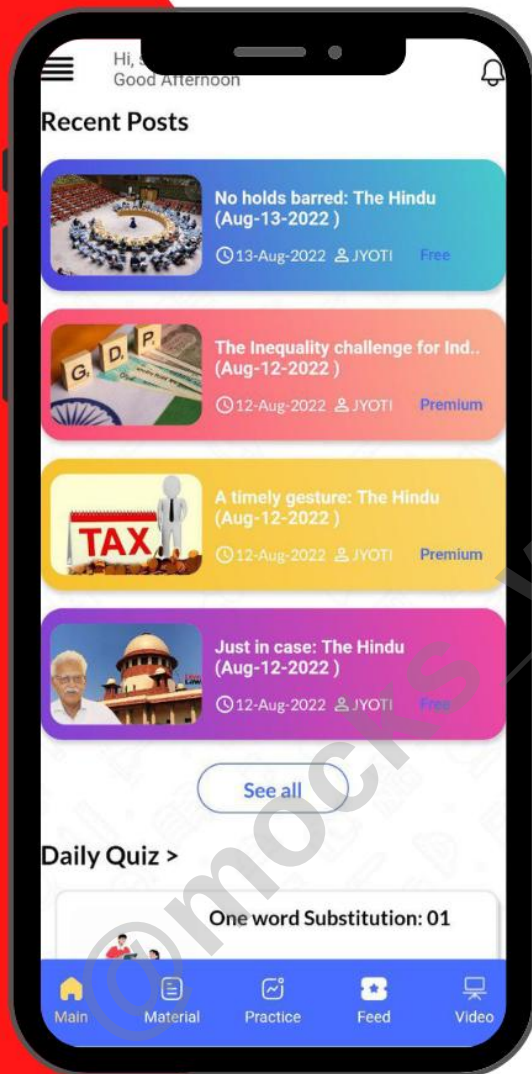
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